



Summary

In this poem, Emily Dickinson dramatizes humankind's epic struggle between fate and free will. In the first stanza, Dickinson sets up contradictory actions, where fate does one thing, but man does the opposite. Fate kills man, but he does not go down; fate drops him, but he does not fall. Man is impaled upon stakes, but is unaffected by them. In the second stanza, fate does her worst upon man, but he remains unmoved, and ultimately proves his strong character.

Read

- 1 Fate slew Him, but He did not drop—
- 2 She **felled** —He did not fall—
- 3 Impaled Him on Her fiercest stakes—
- 4 He **neutralized** them all—

- 5 She stung Him— **sapped** His firm Advance—
- 6 But when Her Worst was done
- 7 And He—unmoved regarded Her—
- 8 **Acknowledged** Him a Man.

Annotations
